BOOKS

Not All Fun And Games

In *Boundary Lab*, Nandan Kamath examines the phenomenon of sports, "the world's largest social experiment"

The American philosopher Bernard Suits defined the playing of sport as "the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles". After all, the easiest way to get a tiny, dimpled ball into a hole far away would be to walk up and drop it in. The clubs, the bunkers and water hazards in golf are arbitrary obstacles that have to be overcome by following rules we have voluntarily adopted.

Boundary Lab is about unnecessary obstacles too—those created by the governing bodies in India for example, those caused by insufficient or ill-understood scientific research, those caused by politics, and sometimes by outright cheating. Sport is not like life. It is life.

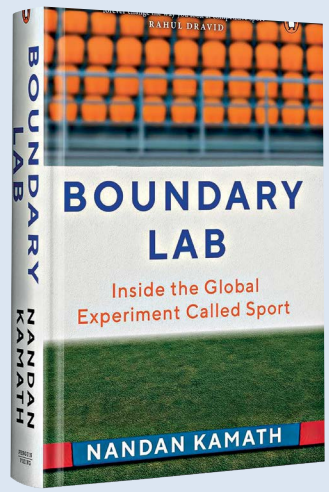
"Organised sport," says Kamath, "is a global sandbox, and perhaps the world's largest social experiment." Kamath is well placed both to raise and to answer such questions as what is sport (three major considerations are involved: the type of activity, clear rules and a competitive structure), what does autonomy mean, does Virat Kohli play for an 'Indian' team? Should men and women compete separately in sports like chess, and as India contemplates hosting the Olympics in 2036, should we?

As a cricketer (he played for the Karnataka juniors), Rhodes Scholar, lawyer and founder of the GoSports Foundation, Kamath comes to these questions from various directions. He writes with authority, wearing the immense research lightly.

"Sport has helped me understand myself better," he writes, and asks, "Does it also have the power to do this for society at large?" Yes, but only if we are willing to learn its lessons. For example, conflict of interest was once the hot topic in Indian sport. It led to two presidents of the Board of Control for Cricket in India losing their jobs and the Supreme Court bringing in new rules of administration. Yet, the concept continued to be misunderstood or ignored. A later president endorsing a competitor of the official sponsor of the board got away with it.

Boundary Lab is also a primer for the understanding of sport. Why do we prioritise and reward skill and disparage pursuits involving chance? Are data analytics becoming too intrusive? When does an injury inflicted on the field become a legal case? The essays deal with major concerns: drugs, gender, fixing, betting, fandom, television, unused stadiums, hosting the Olympics. Written with an awareness that sport is not a single-themed narrative by taking it beyond the sentimental clichés that have attached themselves to it, *Boundary Lab* is an insider's book that combines objectivity and passion. A decade from now, it will be interesting to see how some of the issues raised in it are resolved. ■

–Suresh Menon



BOUNDARY LAB
Inside the Global Experiment Called Sport
by Nandan Kamath
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